.things that Matter

Project Charter

Document Information	
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Company Name	**.things that Matter**
Document Type	**Project Charter**
Version	**1.0**
Date	**January 21, 2026**
Status	**Draft - Pending Approval**

1. Executive Summary

1.1 Company Vision

.things that Matter is building the infrastructure for **Object-Oriented Commerce** — a paradigm shift where products become portable, self-sovereign digital objects that can be transacted anywhere on the internet without requiring users to visit traditional storefronts.

1.2 The Problem

The internet today is architected around "Places." To purchase an item, users must: - Navigate to a specific URL - Load a heavy storefront - Parse a unique user interface - Operate within a walled garden

This model is fundamentally broken because it: - Rigidly couples the product to the platform - Assumes commerce is a destination, not a capability - Is inefficient for AI agents (high compute cost to parse HTML/JSON) - Creates friction in social sharing and discovery

1.3 The Solution

We are building a **Commerce Compiler** that transforms product data into portable, intelligent digital objects called **Universal Commerce Containers** (`.thing` files). These artifacts:

- Carry their own identity, price, semantic meaning, and checkout logic - Are visually shareable for humans (embedded in images) - Are computationally efficient for AI agents (binary format) - Travel freely across the web without platform dependency

1.4 Key Innovation: The Distribution Trinity

Every product processed by our compiler exists simultaneously as:

1. **Matter Photo (Visual Vector)**: A stunning product image with commerce payload baked into pixels and metadata 2. **Matter URI (Pointer Vector)**: A `matter://` protocol link for text-based environments 3. **.thing File (Atomic Vector)**: Raw binary file for direct transfer (the "MP3 of Commerce")

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2. Business Objectives

2.1 Primary Objectives

Objective	Target	Timeline
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Build functional Commerce Compiler	MVP operational	August 2026
Launch browser extension	Chrome Web Store	December 2026
Onboard beta merchants	5-10 merchants	Q4 2026
Process product catalog	10,000+ products	Q4 2026
Achieve technical proof-of-concept	End-to-end demo	August 2026

2.2 Success Criteria

Metric	Target
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Steganography survival rate	≥50% across platforms
Compiler processing speed	<500ms per product
Browser extension adoption	100+ beta users

Merchant satisfaction	**>80% positive feedback**

Technical debt ratio	**<20% of codebase**

2.3 Strategic Positioning

.things that Matter positions as **infrastructure**, not a marketplace: - We build the "physics" that allow products to travel freely - Revenue through compiler API access, not transaction fees - Open standard encourages ecosystem adoption - Network effects from `.thing` format adoption

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3. Scope Definition

3.1 In Scope

Component	Description
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Commerce Compiler (matter-core)	**Rust library that ingests product data and outputs .thing files**
FlatBuffers Schema	**Binary format definition for Universal Commerce Containers**
CLIP Integration	**Semantic vectorization for product "cognition"**
Ed25519 Signing	**Cryptographic integrity for tamper-proof files**
Steganography Engine	**Image embedding for polyglot media distribution**

XMP Metadata Injection	**Fast discovery layer for crawlers/extensions**
matter:// Protocol	**Custom URI scheme for text-based distribution**
Shadow Index API	**Hash-to-artifact resolution service**
Cloudflare R2 CDN	**Artifact storage and distribution**
Browser Extension (Lens)	**Chrome extension for product discovery and checkout**
libmatter SDK	**Developer library with Rust/TypeScript bindings**

3.2 Out of Scope (Year 1)

Item	Rationale
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Mobile SDK (iOS/Android)	**Deferred to Year 2**
Self-hosted GPU cluster	**Use serverless CLIP initially**
SOC2 compliance	**No enterprise customers in Year 1**
Payment processing	**Redirect to merchant checkout**
Inventory management	**Merchants handle fulfillment**
Customer support platform	**Manual support initially**

3.3 Dependencies

Dependency	Type	Risk Level
Replicate API (CLIP)	External service	Medium
Cloudflare R2	Infrastructure	Low
Chrome Web Store	Distribution	Low
FlatBuffers library	Open source	Low
Rust toolchain	Development	Low

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4. Stakeholders

4.1 Core Team

Role	Name	Responsibilities
CEO	Sobuhle Nyambali	Strategy, partnerships, fundraising
CTO	Matome Mboweni	Technical architecture, development, delivery

4.2 Target Users

User Type	Description	Primary Need
Merchants	E-commerce businesses	Distribute products beyond their storefront
Consumers	Online shoppers	Discover and purchase without friction
AI Agents	Autonomous commerce bots	Efficient product data parsing
Developers	Third-party integrators	Easy SDK for Matter-enabled apps

4.3 External Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Interest
Investors	ROI, market traction
Platform partners	Integration opportunities
Open-source community	Standard adoption

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5. Project Governance

5.1 Decision-Making Authority

Decision Type	Authority
Strategic direction	CEO
Technical architecture	CTO
Budget allocation	CEO + CTO jointly
Feature prioritization	CTO (with CEO input)
Partnership agreements	CEO
Hiring decisions	CEO + CTO jointly

5.2 Communication Cadence

Meeting	Frequency	Participants	Purpose
Strategy sync	Weekly	CEO + CTO	Alignment, blockers
Progress demo	Monthly	CEO + CTO	Working software review
Investor update	Quarterly	CEO	Progress report

5.3 Reporting Structure

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CEO (Sobuhle Nyambali)
 └── CTO (Matome Mboweni)
      └── Development (solo initially)
      └── Future: Engineering team
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6. Constraints & Assumptions

6.1 Constraints

Constraint	Impact
Budget: R72,000 Year 1	**Lean development, free tiers prioritized**
Solo developer	**Sequential work, no parallelization**
11-month timeline	**Extended from 9 months due to budget**
No security audit budget	**Self-review until revenue allows**

6.2 Assumptions

Assumption	Risk if Invalid

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Steganography survives ≥50% of platforms	Pivot to matter:// primary distribution
CLIP serverless costs remain stable	May need self-hosted GPU
Chrome allows extension publishing	May need alternative distribution
Rust learning curve manageable	C/C++ background accelerates learning
Merchants interested in beta	Extended timeline for adoption

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7. Budget Summary

7.1 Year 1 Budget: R72,000

Category	Amount (ZAR)	% of Total
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Development Tools	R6,048	8%
AI & ML APIs	R21,600	30%
Infrastructure & Hosting	R7,560	10%
Monitoring & Operations	R0	0%

Payments & Financial	**R10,800**	**15%**
Domains & Publishing	**R500**	**1%**
One-Time Costs	**R2,800**	**4%**
Buffer (5%)	**R3,600**	**5%**
Operating Reserve	**R19,092**	**27%**

7.2 Monthly Burn Rate

Phase	Monthly Avg	Duration
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Setup (Month 1-2)	**R7,250**	**2 months**
Development (Month 3-7)	**R6,100**	**5 months**
Launch prep (Month 8-11)	**R6,550**	**4 months**

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8. High-Level Timeline

8.1 Phase Overview

Phase	Duration	Key Deliverable

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Phase 0: Validation	**Feb 2026 (4 weeks)**	**Steganography proof-of-concept**
Phase 1: Foundation	**Mar-Apr 2026**	**FlatBuffers schema, Rust compiler**
Phase 2: Core	**May-Jul 2026**	**CLIP integration, signing, steg engine**
Phase 3: Distribution	**Aug-Sep 2026**	**CDN, Shadow Index, browser extension**
Phase 4: Launch	**Oct-Dec 2026**	**Beta merchants, public release**

8.2 Key Milestones

Milestone	Target Date	Success Criteria
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Phase 0 Go/No-Go	**Feb 28, 2026**	**≥50% steganography survival**
50% completion	**Jun 30, 2026**	**Working compiler + CLIP**
75% completion	**Aug 31, 2026**	**Browser extension functional**
Beta launch	**Oct 31, 2026**	**5 merchants onboarded**
Public launch	**Dec 15, 2026**	**Chrome Web Store published**

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9. Risk Summary

9.1 Top Risks

Risk	Probability	Impact	Mitigation
Steganography fails on major platforms	Medium	High	Phase 0 validation, matter:// fallback
Cursor Pro limits slow development	Medium	Medium	Batch work, use slow requests
Rust learning takes longer	Low	Medium	C/C++ background provides strong foundation
No merchant interest	Low	High	Open-source for developer adoption
Budget overrun	Medium	Medium	5% buffer, strict scope control

9.2 Risk Tolerance

Risk Type	Tolerance
Technical risk	High (can pivot approaches)
Timeline risk	Medium (2-month buffer acceptable)

Budget risk	**Low (fixed allocation)**
Security risk	**Medium (self-review until audit)**

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10. Approval

10.1 Charter Approval

By signing below, stakeholders approve this Project Charter and authorize the project to proceed.

Role	Name	Signature	Date
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CEO	**Sobuhle Nyambali**		**/_/2026**
CTO	**Matome Mboweni**		**/_/2026**

10.2 Change Control

Changes to this charter require written approval from both CEO and CTO. Minor updates (clarifications, typos) may be made by CTO with notification to CEO.

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11. Document Control

Version	Date	Author	Changes
1.0	Jan 21, 2026	M. Mboweni	Initial draft

Next Document: Technical Architecture Document